



newspapers, may shape and influence their views and opinions of the world around them. Gerbner went on to say that this is not like the 'hypodermic model' but rather depends on what the audience already believes. Newspapers function as **opinion leaders** and mediate the news for the readers with their political allegiance in mind. These views will be cultivated and reinforced by the newspaper, its content and focus. The messages communicated by the *Daily Mirror*, with its left-wing ideology, such as that of the Conservative Party as elitist and Reform UK as racist and corrupt, need to resonate with an established belief in the audience of working-class, left-wing men and women.

## Reception theory – Hall

The producers of newspapers **encode** ideas in their publications that are to be **decoded** by their readers. Active audiences who agree with the ideology of the newspaper will accept the viewpoint of the newspaper that is evident in its approach to and mediation of stories. Those readers who have a different political allegiance will have an **oppositional response**, disagreeing with the messages constructed by the newspaper and will not buy/read a publication that does not reflect their ideas and opinions.

## End of audience theory – Shirky (A Level)

There has been a significant change in recent years in how audiences consume newspapers. The concept of audience members as passive consumers is no longer tenable in the age of digital technologies that offer a range of platforms through which news can be delivered. This development has enabled the rise of the **prosumer** who creates their own content, submitting stories as a **citizen journalist**, offering an immediate perspective on news events. Consumers can now also actively engage and 'speak back' to the news media. The *Daily Mirror's* website offers opportunities for readers to comment on stories and features, thus giving them a voice as part of the newspaper's community.

## Contexts

### Social and cultural

Newspapers reflect the society and culture in which they are produced. The *Daily Mirror* is a left-wing publication in a largely right-wing press environment. The newspaper is known for its support of the ordinary working-class person and regularly runs stories and campaigns related to social issues and perceived inequalities. The *Daily Mirror* has supported a range of social campaigns including justice for the victims of the Hillsborough tragedy and homelessness and has called for change in the law regarding organ donation. It's 'Missed' campaign in 2025 in conjunction with the charity 'Missing People', raised awareness of the 170,000 people who go missing in the UK every year and was shortlisted for the 'Making A Difference Award'.



### Think!

Consider how social and cultural context is evident in the issue of the newspaper you have studied.

### Economic

The newspaper industry has faced economic pressure in recent years as the sale of print copies has steadily fallen. Newspapers like the *Daily Mirror*, which are part of larger